

HOW COMMUNITIES CAN STOP DESTRUCTIVE DEVELOPMENT PROJECTS IN ANGOLA

Complete Community Opposition How-To

INTRODUCTION & FRAMEWORK

Community action shapes what happens to the land of Angola, and one rural community showed that even where the powerful remove people from their ancestral ground for the sake of extraction, a community can use its customary rights, the courts, and the support of a strong institution to win real redress — though the win is partial and the road is dangerous. When mining companies took the land of families in the south of the country for black-granite quarrying, driving them from ground their forebears had held and farmed, and left them without homes or compensation, the community did not simply vanish into poverty as so many displaced people have. Grounded in the customary land rights that Angolan law recognises, and supported by the justice-and-peace commission of the Catholic Church — an institution with a reach and a standing that a scattered rural community lacks — they brought their case to court. And they won a court order that the mining companies must build new homes for the roughly one hundred and thirty displaced families: a rare and significant victory for customary land rights in a country where such rights have long been trampled. The quarrying was not stopped, and the broader picture remains grim — resistance has met arrest and worse. But families who had been erased from the record won homes and recognition, and a precedent was set that the powerful must answer for those they displace. It is worth setting down what that community actually achieved, because it shows both the power and the hard limits of a rural community's fight in Angola. The harm was stark: families removed from ancestral, customary land for black-granite quarrying, their homes gone and no compensation paid, thrown into the food insecurity that follows when subsistence farmers lose their ground. Rather than accept this erasure, the community grounded its claim in the customary land rights that Angolan law recognises, and — crucially — it did not stand alone: the Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission, an institution with reach, standing, and a measure of protection that a scattered rural community cannot summon, took up its cause and carried it to court. The result was an order that the mining companies build new homes for the displaced families. That is not the same as stopping the quarry, and it did not undo the loss of the land; but it converted a silent, uncompensated displacement into a public, court-ordered redress, and it laid down a marker that others can build on.

The Angolan story teaches two things about stopping destructive projects here — including its honest limits, which this guide states plainly and up front, because they are serious, and because the dangers are real. The first is the pattern that runs through every guide: not a single silver bullet, but the combination of every lever — the affected community, the documentation, the coalition, and the pressure on the deciders — pressed together. The second is distinctly Angolan, and it won homes for the displaced. **A community — especially a rural one with customary land rights and the support of a strong institution such as the Church — can use those customary rights, the courts, and its institutional allies to win real redress for displacement and destruction, and to set precedents for accountability, even where stopping the project itself is out of reach and where resistance is dangerous.** That power — the customary land rights, the institutional ally, and the courts — is Angola's distinctive lever, and this guide is built around it. What makes this lever distinctive, and worth understanding precisely, is that it does not rest on a friendly state — which a rural community fighting a favoured extractor will not have — nor on a dangerous confrontation, but on two things a community can build: a recognised legal foundation and a powerful ally. Angolan law genuinely recognises the customary rights of rural communities and requires that those

displaced be compensated or rehoused, which gives a community a real legal handle even against the powerful. And a strong institution such as the Church can supply what the community lacks: the reach to be heard, the standing the powerful cannot ignore, the resources to litigate, and — in a dangerous setting — a measure of protection for those who would otherwise be exposed. The community's task is therefore to establish its rights and to win such an ally, so that redress can be pursued through law rather than through a confrontation that has cost others dearly — which is what the Huíla community did.

But the same story carries honest and grave warnings, and this guide will not hide them; it places them first and takes them with the utmost seriousness. The community did **not** stop the quarrying; the win was **redress for displacement**, not a project halted. It was, as observers noted, an **isolated court victory** in a landscape that needs deep legislative reform to be safe. And — this above all — **resistance in Angola is dangerous**: in one municipality, community members who tried to protect their grazing land were **arrested and tried**; elsewhere, protesters against mining conditions have been **killed**. This guide is written with both truths in view: the real, distinctive power of customary rights, the courts, and an institutional ally — and the partial nature of the win, the slowness of the courts, and, most gravely, the real physical and legal danger, which qualify everything and demand caution. These qualifications are not footnotes; they are the core of an honest and sober picture, and a community must weigh them with the greatest care before it acts. The partial nature of the win is the first: Huíla won homes and recognition, not an end to the quarrying, and a community should aim realistically at redress and precedent rather than expect a project halted. The slowness of the courts is real: Angolan land cases run for years, so litigation is a long road that a strong ally must help sustain. And the danger — this above all — is grave and must never be underestimated: in one municipality, community members who tried to protect their grazing land were arrested and put on trial; elsewhere, protesters against mining conditions were killed. A community in Angola must therefore build its campaign to minimise exposure — leaning on law, on a protective institution, and on careful attention rather than on confrontation — and must never ask of anyone a risk they have not freely and knowingly chosen. If your fight, too, is against displacement by a powerful extractive project, and you have customary rights and an ally to stand with you, this is the guide for it — clear-eyed about how hard, and how dangerous, it is.

Most communities do not know HOW to make that power effective. They watch the machines take their land and assume "the powerful always win and nothing can be done," and never assert their customary rights, never find an institutional ally, never bring the case. They suffer displacement without redress. The gap between homes won and families erased is rarely apathy — the Huíla families proved a community will fight. It is method: knowing how to assert customary rights, find a strong ally, document the harm, and win redress through the courts — safely as possible.

This guide shows what actually works — inside the Angolan system as it is, with its real limits and real dangers.

The Strategic Framework

Effective campaigns follow the same underlying pattern, whether the goal is to resist displacement, win redress, or protect land from a destructive project:

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION	(find the project, the harm, and the deciders)
STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION	(build the evidence and the customary claim)
STEP 3: LOCAL OPPOSITION	(build the community and the institutional ally)
STEP 4: LEGAL & CUSTOMARY	(customary rights, the Church commission, the courts)
STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY	(make it a national and international cause -- safely)

These steps operate **simultaneously, not in sequence**. The customary claim feeds the litigation and the ally at once; the community and its ally grow together; a documented harm is both evidence and a spur to the next. The community that runs all five together, each reinforcing the others — and each mindful of the danger — is the one that wins what can be won: redress, recognition, a precedent. The Huíla community did this — it asserted its customary rights, found a strong ally, and won in court.

The Levers That Are Distinctly Strong Here

Every country's system has its own pressure points. Angola's give communities a distinctive set — though each must be used with care:

- **Customary land rights.** Angolan law **recognises the customary rights** of rural communities and requires compensation and rehousing for those displaced, as the Huíla families' rights grounded their case. This is the lever that most distinguishes an Angolan fight of this kind, and it rewards close attention. In law, all land in Angola belongs to the state; but the same law recognises that rural communities hold customary rights over the land they use, that such community land cannot be transferred without the agreement of the Traditional Authorities, and that where it is taken, those affected must be granted alternative land or fair compensation. This means a rural community is not, in law, a squatter to be brushed aside, but a recognised holder of rights whose land cannot lawfully be taken without consent and compensation — and where those requirements were ignored, as they so often are, the community has a genuine legal grievance a court can act on. Establishing the customary right, with the Traditional Authorities and the community's own history of use, is therefore the foundation on which the whole case for redress is built.
- **The institutional ally.** A **strong institution** such as the Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission lends reach, protection, and standing, as it did in Huíla. The value of such an ally in Angola is hard to overstate, and it works on several levels at once. A strong institution like the Church's justice-and-peace commission has a national and international reach that a remote rural community lacks, so that a displacement which would otherwise go unnoticed becomes a case the powerful must answer. It has a standing and a moral authority that the state and the extractor cannot easily dismiss or intimidate. It has the resources and the expertise — lawyers, documentation, networks — to carry a slow and costly case through the courts. And, in a setting where resistance has met arrest and death, its presence lends a measure of protection to those who would otherwise stand exposed. Winning such an ally is therefore often the single most consequential thing an Angolan community can do, as the Huíla families' alliance with the Church was for them.
- **The courts.** The **courts**, slow and imperfect, can order **redress and set precedents**, as they ordered homes for the displaced.
- **The Traditional Authorities.** The **traditional leaders**, whose agreement the law requires to transfer community land, are a source of standing and legitimacy.
- **The international attention.** A story of **displacement for extraction** draws national and international attention and allies, as Huíla's did.

What This Guide Will Not Pretend

It would be dishonest to promise these levers stop a project or keep a community safe. The Huíla quarrying **continued**; the win was **redress**; the courts are **slow**; and, gravely, resistance has met **arrest and death**. This guide takes those limits and dangers with the utmost seriousness — it states them first and throughout — and shows you how to use the real, distinctive tools Angola offers — customary rights, an institutional ally, and the courts — as the Huíla families used them to win homes and recognition, while urging the

caution that the danger demands.

HOW THE SYSTEM WORKS

You cannot pull a lever you cannot see. Before you spend a single week, map who actually decides your land's fate, at which level, and where along that path the project — or the leverage — is weakest. And map the customary rights you can assert and the ally you can find, because in Angola displacement by a destructive project is often best resisted by grounding a case in customary land rights, standing with a strong institution, and bringing it to the courts — carefully, for the danger is real.

The Levels of Decision

An Angolan project runs through several tracks at once, and each is a place to intervene — though some come with grave risk.

The state. The **state** owns all land in law, grants the concessions extractors need, and — honestly — often **favours extraction and the powerful**, and treats resistance harshly; so it is a force to be pressured through law and allies, not a protector to rely on, and confronting it directly can be dangerous.

The customary rights and Traditional Authorities. The **customary land rights** of rural communities, and the **traditional leaders** whose agreement the law requires to transfer community land, are a real legal foundation, as they were for the Huíla families.

The courts. The **courts** can order **compensation, rehousing, and redress**, and set precedents, though — honestly — they are **slow and costly**, as the Huíla case shows.

The institutional ally. A **strong institution** — above all the Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission — can lend the reach, standing, and a measure of protection a rural community lacks, as it did in Huíla.

The public and the world. The **national and international attention** to displacement and extraction is a lever, though it must be used with care in a dangerous setting.

The Journey of a Project

A typical project moves from a state concession, through the taking of land, toward displacement, destruction, and the loss of livelihood — with the **community's customary rights, its ally, and the courts** able to intervene, above all to win **redress**. **Several of those stages are places you can act**, and the customary claim carried by a strong ally to the courts is the distinctive Angolan door. The distinctive levers are the **customary rights**, the **institutional ally**, the **courts**, and the **Traditional Authorities**. Find out exactly where the project stands, and, crucially, **what customary rights you hold, what ally will stand with you, and what redress the courts can order**, because those are often where a community can win — safely — what can be won.

Follow the Project, the Harm, and the Deciders

Behind a project stand an extractor — often a powerful company — and the state that grants its concession. Trace who decides, who profits, and — importantly here — **what customary rights the community holds, what harm and displacement the project causes, what strong ally will stand with the community, and what redress the courts can order**. Two questions unlock most Angolan fights of this kind: **What customary rights can the community assert, and who will stand with them?** and **What redress — compensation, rehousing, protection — can the courts be brought to order?** The customary rights and

the institutional ally are, together, the heart of most such campaigns. These two work together in a way particular to the fight here: the customary rights supply the legal foundation — the recognised claim and the redress the law owes — and the institutional ally supplies the reach, the standing, the resources, and the protection to press that claim where a community alone could not, and could not safely. A community with rights but no strong ally may have a genuine claim that is never heard or is dangerous to raise; one with an ally but no grounded customary right has support but no legal foundation for redress. Joined together — a recognised customary right carried by a strong institution through the courts — they make redress achievable and pursuit safer, which is how the Huíla families won homes without paying the terrible price that confrontation has exacted elsewhere.

The Overseers

Finally, know the bodies and forces that can check the deciders, because they are levers too — though each has limits and some carry risk. The **courts**, slow but able to order redress; the **customary land rights** and the **Traditional Authorities**; the **Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission** and other strong institutions; the **national and international press and rights organisations**; and the **community** itself, standing together. In Angola, the **customary rights, the institutional ally, the courts, and the Traditional Authorities** are the most distinctive levers. Each is a separate front, and a community with recognised customary rights, standing with a strong institution, pressing its case in the courts, and drawing careful attention rarely loses everything — as the Huíla families did not, winning homes even where the quarrying went on. The phrase “rarely loses everything” is chosen with care, and honestly: in Angola, against a favoured extractor and a harsh state, a community often cannot win everything, and sometimes the realistic aim is not to stop the project but to ensure that those it harms are not simply erased — that they are compensated, rehoused, and recognised, and that a precedent is set for the next community. That is a lesser victory than a project halted, but it is a real one, and for the families who receive homes and recognition it is far from nothing. A community should therefore enter the fight with clear eyes about what is winnable, aiming for the redress and recognition that customary rights, a strong ally, and the courts can secure, rather than staking everything — including its people's safety — on a stop that the tilt of the system makes unlikely. But move always with an eye to the danger, for in Angola resistance has cost people their freedom and their lives.

QUICK REFERENCE: SUCCESS RATES

Before you commit months of effort, calibrate honestly — and here, more than almost anywhere, that means expecting a partial win, a long road, and real danger. These figures are **directional, not guarantees** — patterns drawn from how Angolan and comparable campaigns tend to go, not a controlled study. The decisive variables are whether the community holds **customary rights**, whether a **strong ally** will stand with it, whether the **harm and displacement can be documented**, and whether the **courts can be reached**. Where the rights are clear and an ally strong, the levers here are real, as Huíla shows; but temper every figure heavily with the honest knowledge that the state favours extraction, that the courts are slow, that the win is usually redress rather than a stop, and — gravely — that resistance carries the risk of arrest and worse.

Individual Step Success Rates

Approach	Success Rate	Timeline	Cost	What "Success" Means
Documentation only	5–15%	weeks	low	Basis for every other step

ally is weak, or whose setting is especially dangerous is in the weaker band and should aim realistically at a record and a precedent — and should weigh, above all, whether the fight can be pursued safely. Knowing which band you are in keeps a campaign both determined where the rights and the ally are strong and realistic — and cautious — where the ground is hard and the danger great.

Step Importance Ranking (When All Combined)

1. **The institutional ally** — Angola's force-multiplier; the reach, standing, and protection a strong institution lends, as the Church did in Huíla.
2. **The customary rights** — the distinctive legal foundation; the recognised rights of rural communities.
3. **The courts** — the slow but real path to redress and precedent.
4. **The Traditional Authorities** — the standing and legitimacy of the traditional leaders.
5. **The careful attention** — the visibility that draws allies and lends some protection.

What Angolan Campaigns Actually Show

A few patterns recur. **Customary rights give a foundation** — recognised rights are a real legal handle. **A strong ally multiplies a community** — an institution lends reach, standing, and protection a scattered community lacks. **The courts can order redress** — slowly, and imperfectly, they can require compensation and rehousing. **The Traditional Authorities carry legitimacy** — their standing strengthens a claim. **But the state favours extraction, and resistance is dangerous** — the win is usually partial, and the risk is grave. The through-line: **assert customary rights; win a strong ally; document the harm; press the courts for redress; engage the Traditional Authorities — because in Angola a community with recognised rights and a powerful ally can win redress, recognition, and precedents even against a powerful extractor, though a stop is rare and the danger real, so move with care.**

STEP 1: TARGET IDENTIFICATION

Every effective campaign begins by finding the exact project and harm that govern the threat — and the leverage the community holds, which here is often the customary rights and the ally. Vague opposition goes nowhere; a fight aimed at "the quarry that took our customary land and displaced us without compensation, whose harm we can document, and against which our rights and our ally can win us redress in the courts" is a campaign — the kind that won homes in Huíla. Answer five questions — and weigh the danger throughout.

The Five Core Questions

1. What customary rights does the community hold? This is the first Angolan question of this kind. What **recognised customary rights** to the land does the community hold, as the Huíla families held. Assess this honestly and precisely at the outset, because in Angola the clarity of the customary right is what most determines what redress a community can win. A community whose historical use of the land is well established, and whose Traditional Authorities affirm its claim, holds a right the law recognises and a court can act on. A community whose claim is contested or poorly documented has a weaker foundation, and should work first to establish and record its right, with its traditional leaders and its own history. The strength of that customary claim is the ground on which the ally, the litigation, and every other lever depend, so a community should establish it carefully and early, as the Huíla families' recognised rights were the foundation of all that followed.

2. What strong ally will stand with the community? Which **strong institution** — the Church's justice-and-peace commission, a rights organisation — will lend reach, standing, and protection, as the Church did in Huíla. This question deserves early and serious attention, because in Angola a strong ally is not a luxury but very often the decisive factor — and, in a dangerous setting, a source of protection. A scattered rural community rarely has, on its own, the reach to be heard, the standing to resist intimidation, or the resources to litigate for years; a strong institution supplies all three. The Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission is the clearest example, with its national and international networks, its moral authority, and its long engagement with land and displacement; but other rights organisations and strong institutions can play a similar role. Identifying early which ally can and will stand with the community therefore shapes what the whole campaign can attempt, and how safely it can proceed.

3. What harm and displacement can be documented? What **displacement, destruction, and loss** can be recorded — the taking of land, the lost homes, the ruined livelihood.

4. What redress can the courts order? What **compensation, rehousing, or protection** can the courts be brought to order, as they ordered homes in Huíla.

5. Who decides, who profits, and how dangerous is it? Which extractor and officials are behind it, who profits; whether the Traditional Authorities were bypassed; and — crucially — **how dangerous** resistance would be, so people can be kept safe.

A Worked Example

Suppose a powerful extractor takes a community's customary land, displacing families without proper compensation.

Working the five questions: **what customary rights does the community hold? What ally will stand with it? What harm can be documented? What redress can the courts order?** And the deciders are the state and the extractor, with the customary rights, the ally, and the courts as the levers — while weighing, above all, the danger, so no one is exposed carelessly.

Within a season you have moved from "the powerful always win and nothing can be done" to a target list: assert the customary rights; win a strong ally; document the harm; press the courts for redress; engage the Traditional Authorities — and protect the people. That is a campaign, not a surrender — and it draws directly on how Huíla won homes for the displaced. Notice what the exercise did: it turned a sense that the powerful always win and nothing can be done into a set of concrete, workable tasks — assert the rights, win an ally, document the harm, press for redress, engage the traditional leaders — each tied to a specific lever that Angola genuinely provides, each honest about its limits, and each mindful of the danger. That reframing, from despair before a favoured extractor to a plan built on customary rights and a strong ally, is the difference the questions make, and the first two — the rights the community holds and the ally it can win — largely determine what redress is within reach.

STEP 2: DOCUMENTATION — HOW TO BUILD AN UNASSAILABLE CASE

Documentation is the foundation everything else stands on — and here, where the state favours the extractor and the courts demand proof, a solid record of rights and harm is essential. The court, the ally, a journalist, and the community all move on evidence, not indignation — and in Angola, the customary rights and the documented displacement are precisely what a campaign turns into redress, so build them well and early, and safely. The order matters as much as the content: because the danger is real and the courts are

slow, a community does well to establish its customary right and secure a strong ally before it presses its case in public, so that when the fight becomes visible the community already stands on a firm legal foundation and behind a protective institution, rather than exposed and alone. Build your file in three layers.

Layer 1: The Project, the Concession, and the Deciders

Get the facts the case turns on. Identify the **project, its owner, its concession, and the state authority** behind it; and establish **whether the Traditional Authorities were consulted** and whether the taking of land followed the law, as the Huíla quarrying took customary land. Establish the deciders and the project precisely — including, honestly, the state's backing and the danger — because they are what the case must answer.

Layer 2: The Rights and the Harm

Document the two things the case most needs. First, the **customary rights**: record, with the Traditional Authorities and the community's own history, the community's **recognised customary claim** to the land, as the Huíla families' rights were their foundation. Second, the **harm and displacement**: record the **taking of land, the lost homes, the destroyed livelihood, the food insecurity, the absence of compensation** — with testimony, photographs, and any documents. Together, a clear customary right and a documented harm are the heart of a case for redress. Both halves deserve care, because a court granting redress needs to see both that the community held a right and that the right was violated to its harm. The customary right is established less by a title deed than by the community's recognised, historical use of the land and by the affirmation of the Traditional Authorities, so it is worth recording that history and that affirmation carefully. The harm is established by the concrete facts of the displacement — the homes lost, the land taken, the livelihoods destroyed, the compensation never paid — documented through testimony, photographs, and whatever record can be safely gathered. A file that shows clearly both a recognised customary right and a documented, uncompensated displacement gives a court, and a strong ally, exactly what they need to act, as the Huíla families' case did.

Layer 3: The Rights, the Redress, and the Ally

Finally, document the case. Do the **customary rights** ground a claim? Is the **harm and displacement** clearly recorded? What **redress** — compensation, rehousing, protection — can be sought? And which **strong ally** will carry it? Each is a separate ground — for the court, the ally, the press, and the community — and together they make a case that is hard to dismiss, even by a state that favours the extractor. This is the layer that most often decides Angolan fights of this kind, because here a recognised customary right, a documented displacement, and a concrete redress are joined and carried by a strong ally — exactly the case that won homes in Huíla, where recognised customary rights, a documented removal, and the Church's justice-and-peace commission together moved a court to order the powerful to make redress. Build it carefully, and guard the safety of all who help.

WHAT TO GATHER, AND WHERE TO FIND IT

This is the practical companion to Step 2: the specific records that decide Angolan cases of this kind, and where to obtain them — safely. You will not need every item; you will need the few that establish the customary right, prove the harm, and point to redress.

The Project, the Rights, and the Paper Trail

- **The project and concession** — what operates, by whom, under what state concession.

- **The customary rights** — the community's recognised customary claim and the Traditional Authorities.
- **The harm and displacement** — the taking of land, the lost homes, the ruined livelihood.
- **The absence of due process** — whether consultation, consent, and compensation were given.
- **The redress owed** — the compensation, rehousing, or protection the law requires.

How to Get Them

The project and concession are matters of state record, though — honestly — hard to obtain and sometimes dangerous to pursue, so gather what you safely can and note what is withheld. The **customary rights** are established through the **Traditional Authorities and the community's own history and usage**, as the Huíla families' rights were. The **harm and displacement** are recorded through **testimony, photographs, and the community's own account**, gathered carefully. Lean above all on a **strong ally**: the Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission, rights organisations, and lawyers, who can gather evidence, establish rights, and carry the case with a reach and a protection a community lacks, as the Church did in Huíla. Move carefully, for the courts are slow and the setting dangerous.

The Ground Evidence

- **The customary right** — the recognised claim, backed by the Traditional Authorities.
- **The documented displacement** — the lost land, homes, and livelihood, with testimony.
- **The absence of compensation** — the redress owed and not given.
- **The strong ally** — the institution that will carry the case and lend protection.
- **The redress sought** — the compensation, rehousing, or protection to be won.

Organise It So It Persuades

Keep a **master timeline** of the concession, the taking of land, the displacement, and every step of the fight — the spine of any case in court or appeal to an ally. Keep a **document index** so any fact can be sourced fast. And keep an **argument bank** (developed in a later section) that pairs each fact with what it proves, to whom. A well-ordered file is not bureaucracy; it is what lets a community member, a lawyer, a judge, an ally, and a journalist all see the same clear picture fast, and it guards against the campaign's own worst enemy, a claim that cannot be sourced when the extractor or the state pushes back. In Angola, where the deciders favour the powerful, the campaign with the clearer customary right and the better-documented harm — carried by a strong ally — is very often the one that wins redress, as Huíla's did. And keep your records, and your people, safe.

STEP 3: BUILDING LOCAL OPPOSITION — HOW TO BUILD THE COMMUNITY AND THE ALLY

Evidence does not win on its own. A united community and a strong ally do — and in Angola, the Huíla community proves that a rural community, standing together and standing with the Church, can win redress from a powerful extractor. A campaign's strength here is that unity and that ally: a community that speaks with one voice, backed by an institution the powerful cannot ignore. And because the setting is dangerous, an ally is not only a multiplier but a measure of protection.

Phase 1: The Core, the Rights, and the Ally

Start with a committed core rooted in the **affected community and its Traditional Authorities**, and do the distinctively Angolan first work: **establish the customary rights** and **find a strong ally**, so the claim is grounded and the community is not alone or unprotected, as the Huíla families grounded their rights and found the Church. Assign roles — the customary claim, the documentation, the litigation liaison, the ally relationship — and agree on the goal — redress, rehousing, recognition — and, above all, on how to keep people safe.

Phase 2: The Strong Ally and the Coalition

Then widen deliberately, and win the **strong institutional ally** that is Angola's distinctive strength and protection, as the Huíla community won the Church's justice-and-peace commission. Bring in the **whole affected community and its Traditional Authorities**, whose unity and legitimacy are powerful; the **Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission** or another strong institution, whose reach, standing, and protection multiply the case; **lawyers and rights organisations**, who carry the litigation; sympathetic voices in **the press and public life**, engaged carefully; and **international rights and Church networks**, whose attention lends both weight and some protection. The Huíla campaign drew its power from exactly this — the community, the Traditional Authorities, and above all the Church — which is precisely the spread, and the protection, an Angolan campaign of this kind needs.

A worked coalition example. Facing displacement by a quarry, the community and its Traditional Authorities establish their customary rights; the Church's justice-and-peace commission carries the case and lends protection; and lawyers press it in court. No single group could win redress from a powerful extractor the state favours; together they cover the community, the rights, and the strong ally — the model Huíla built. The lesson of that model is that no single part of a coalition needs to be able to win alone; what matters is that, between them, the parts cover every front an Angolan fight of this kind requires — the community and its Traditional Authorities to hold and voice the customary claim, the strong ally to lend reach and protection, and the lawyers to press the case for redress. A community that maps these fronts and finds a partner for each builds something far stronger, and far safer, than the sum of its parts, and far harder for a favoured extractor and a harsh state to ignore or to intimidate than any one group acting alone.

Phase 3: Sustaining It — and Staying Safe

A campaign can run for years — Angolan court cases are slow — so endurance matters, as does, above all, safety. Meet on a rhythm that can be kept, carefully. Renew the coalition and the ally relationship. Give people concrete tasks — the customary claim, the documentation, the litigation liaison. Mark the gains that come — rights established, a case filed, an ally secured, a redress ordered, a precedent set — because in a long, hard struggle morale is sustained by real gains. Keep the coalition broad and the ally close, and guard above all against the **danger**: resistance in Angola has met **arrest and death**, so keep within the law, avoid confrontation that exposes people, lean on the protection of a strong institution, and never ask of your people a risk they have not freely and knowingly accepted. Value redress won: homes and recognition are real, even where the project goes on. Track and name these gains deliberately, because a campaign that may run for years, in a dangerous setting and against a favoured extractor, will exhaust and dishearten a community if success is measured only by the project's end. A customary right established, a strong ally secured, a case filed, an interim order won, homes rebuilt for even some of the displaced, a precedent set — each is real progress and a sign the strategy is working, and each is a reason for the community to sustain the effort. A campaign that marks its gains keeps its people through a long, hard, and dangerous struggle; one that waits silently for a stop that may never come too often loses heart, and its people, before it has won even the redress that was within reach.

Phase 4: The Community, the Rights, and the Ally

Here is Angola's distinctive strength, on two levels. First, the **community and its rights**: unite the affected community and its Traditional Authorities around their **recognised customary rights**, so the claim is both broad and grounded, as it was in Huíla. Second, and decisively, the **strong ally**: stand with an **institution such as the Church's justice-and-peace commission**, whose reach, standing, and protection a scattered rural community cannot match, as the Huíla families stood with the Church. Keep it **united, rights-based, and allied — and safe**, because in Angola it is a community grounded in its customary rights and standing with a strong ally that wins redress from a powerful extractor — as the Huíla community did, winning homes even where the quarrying went on, and doing so through law and alliance rather than a dangerous confrontation.

STEP 4: LEGAL & CUSTOMARY CHALLENGES — CUSTOMARY LAND RIGHTS, THE CHURCH COMMISSION, AND THE COURTS

Angola's customary land rights, its courts, its compensation and rehousing requirements, and — distinctively — the strong institutions such as the Church's justice-and-peace commission are a real toolkit, though an imperfect and hard-won one you must use with clear eyes and great care. You do not need to stop a project to win: compensation ordered, homes rebuilt, a customary right recognised, a precedent set — each is a real gain, and together they can win redress. Engage lawyers and a strong ally early — but understand both the tools and the danger.

Customary Land Rights and the Traditional Authorities

The first lever is the **customary land rights and the Traditional Authorities**. Angolan law **recognises the customary rights** of rural communities, requires their **consent (through the Traditional Authorities) to transfer community land**, and mandates **alternative land or compensation** for those displaced, as the Huíla families' recognised rights grounded their claim. Establish the customary right and the role of the Traditional Authorities; they are the legal foundation of the whole case.

The Church Commission and the Strong Ally

The second and most distinctive lever is the **strong institutional ally**. The **Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission** — or another strong institution — carries a reach, a standing, and a measure of protection that a rural community cannot summon alone, as it carried the Huíla case to a winning judgment. Win such an ally: it is often the difference between a community's grievance ignored and a court's order won, and between exposure and some safety.

The Courts and the Redress

The third lever is the **courts and the redress they can order**. A community, with its ally and its lawyers, can **sue for compensation, rehousing, and recognition**, and even a slow case can win **real redress and set a precedent**, as the Huíla case won homes for the displaced. Honestly, the courts here are slow and costly; but a case carried by a strong ally can win what direct confrontation — which is dangerous — cannot.

Where to Turn and With Whom

The customary right goes through the **Traditional Authorities and the community's history**; the case through the **courts** and lawyers; the reach and protection through the **Church's justice-and-peace commission** or another strong institution; the attention through **careful national and international**

engagement. Get help early: the Church's commission, rights organisations, and lawyers know the customary law, the courts, and how to proceed safely, and they will carry a grounded, well-documented case, as they carried Huíla's. Help engaged early is worth far more than help sought after, and in Angola the strongest strategy marries the **community and its customary rights** to a **strong institutional ally and the courts**, so that a powerful extractor the state favours is still met by a community grounded in recognised rights and backed by an institution the powerful cannot simply ignore — as the Huíla community met the quarry, and won homes for the displaced, through law and alliance and not through a confrontation that would have cost them dearly.

TURNING YOUR EVIDENCE INTO ARGUMENTS

You have a file of evidence. Now you must turn it into arguments — because the same fact persuades a court, a strong ally, a journalist, the Traditional Authorities, and the community in different ways. Learning to translate your evidence for each audience is what lets a community reach every lever at once.

One Fact, Many Arguments

Take a single documented fact — say, that a quarry took a community's customary land and displaced families without homes or compensation. That one fact becomes:

- **A customary-rights argument:** this is our recognised customary land, taken without the consent the law requires — the foundation of the claim.
- **A legal argument:** the law mandates compensation and rehousing for those displaced, and none was given — the case for redress in court.
- **An ally's argument:** here is an injustice of displacement a strong institution should stand against — the case for the Church's or another's support.
- **A traditional-authority argument:** our traditional leaders never consented to this transfer — the case for legitimacy and standing.
- **An international argument:** a powerful extractor has displaced a poor community from its ancestral land — the case that draws attention and some protection.

Same fact, five arguments, five audiences. Go through your strongest facts and, for each, ask what it proves to each audience. That table is your campaign's argument bank — and in Angola the arguments that most often win redress are the **customary-rights** and **legal-redress** ones, because they ground a court's order, and the **ally's** one, because a strong institution can carry what a community cannot. Keep the arguments anchored to the same documented facts, so a claim made to a court can be proven and a claim made to an ally can be trusted; consistency across audiences is itself persuasive. And be honest about the state of the fight: acknowledge the state's bias, the danger, and the partial nature of the likely win, and argue for the redress and recognition that can be won.

Match the Argument to the Audience

The courts want the customary right and the harm framed precisely, with the documents and the testimony.

A strong ally responds to a clear injustice of displacement it can stand against with its reach and standing.

The Traditional Authorities respond to the defence of their community's land and their own role and consent.

Journalists need a specific, vivid story with a hook: a poor community displaced from ancestral land by a powerful extractor.

The community needs the argument clear and close to home: our land, our homes, our livelihood, our rights. The community argument, though it moves people most, must stay anchored to the customary right and the documented harm if it is to serve the other fronts as well. The grief and anger of a displaced community rallies people rightly; but the same case, stated precisely — the recognised right, the specific taking without consent, the compensation owed and not paid — is also what a court and a strong ally require. A campaign that lets the community's pain drift into exaggeration or a claim that cannot be grounded hands the extractor and the state an easy rebuttal and weakens the case built on the same facts. Keep the community argument deeply felt but scrupulously true, so that the loss that stirs the community and the right that moves the court are one and the same, drawn from a single reliable record.

The international world responds to displacement for extraction and to a community's courage against the powerful. Because this audience is moved by exactly such stakes, a campaign gains by framing its case in those terms — carefully. The international community — rights organisations, the Church's own global networks, the outlets that cover extraction and displacement — responds not only to a single community's loss but to the pattern of the powerful displacing the poor from ancestral land for profit, and to the courage of a community that stands on its rights against them. A campaign that can show its fight is both emblematic and lawful speaks directly to what this audience responds to, and can draw the attention, the support, and the protective visibility that a remote community cannot generate alone — the very reach that a strong ally, above all the Church, brings to such a case.

STEP 5: MEDIA STRATEGY — HOW COVERAGE SHIFTS OUTCOMES

Media is not vanity; it is a lever — and in Angola, where the state favours the extractor and resistance is dangerous, careful national and international attention can lend both weight to a case and a measure of protection to those who bring it, so coverage, used wisely, is a powerful lever. Coverage unites the community, strengthens the ally, presses the court, and raises the cost of harming those who resist. The Huíla case drew attention to the displacement — the taken land, the homeless families, the powerful extractor. Coverage of that kind did more than inform the public: it made the displacement a matter of record that the powerful had to answer, it lent weight to the case before the courts, and it drew the eyes of national and international networks whose attention offers a measure of protection to those who resist — which, in a dangerous setting, is a benefit as valuable as the pressure itself.

Build the Story

Reporters and the public need specifics, and here they need the displacement and the injustice. "A quarry is controversial" is not a story; "a powerful extractor took our ancestral, customary land and left our families homeless and uncompensated, and we won a court order to rebuild our homes" is — the kind of story that carried Huíla. Lead with your strongest verified facts — the customary right, the taken land, the homeless families, the court's order — and offer a human voice and the stakes: a displaced elder, a Traditional Authority, an image of the lost land. But weigh safety in every choice: name individuals only with their knowing consent, and lean on the ally's and the institution's voice where exposure is dangerous. In Angola the story of a community winning redress from a powerful extractor is one the nation and the world respond to, and the telling can protect as well as press.

Reach the Right Outlets

Work outward in rings, carefully. **The community and the ally's channels** first. Then the **national outlets**, engaged with care, because displacement for extraction is a national concern. Then, distinctively and importantly, the **international ring** — the world's press, the rights and Church networks, the outlets that cover extraction and displacement — because international attention reaches beyond a state that favours the extractor, draws powerful allies, and lends some protection to those at risk. Feed each ring what it needs, and let coverage in one pull in the next. The **international ring, and the Church's own networks, are distinctly important** here, for their reach and their protection.

Sustain It, and Keep It True and Safe

A single article changes little; a careful drumbeat over years changes decisions. Plan a sequence — the displacement, the customary right, the ally, the case, the redress — so there is always a next hook, and build your own clear record so the story endures. Keep messaging disciplined, accurate, and honest; the extractor and the state will seize on any exaggeration, and a credible, rights-and-displacement-centred campaign is what draws sustained, protective attention. And keep it safe: never let the telling expose people to greater danger than they have chosen. Verified, specific, rights-grounded, and safety-conscious — that is the coverage that shifts outcomes here, and that helped carry Huíla's case.

EMAILS & LETTERS

Written communications are how you assert, request, litigate, create a record, and reach the bodies that can act — the courts, the ally, the Traditional Authorities, the rights organisations, and the press. Each does double duty: it asks for something and it documents that you asked. Keep copies of everything, send important items so that receipt is provable, and — given the danger — take care what you put in writing and to whom. Below are adaptable templates for the situations you will meet most often. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the customary right, the harm, and the redress.

8A. Approach to a Strong Ally (the Church Commission)

To: the Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission / a strong institution

Subject: Support for our displaced community at [place]

We, [community/organisation], the customary holders of land at [place], have been displaced by [extractor] without the compensation the law requires. We ask your commission to stand with us — to help establish our rights, document the harm, and carry our case — as your commission stood with the displaced families of Huíla.

8B. Assertion of Customary Rights

To: the relevant authority / [extractor]

Subject: Our customary rights to the land at [place]

We, [community/organisation], with our Traditional Authorities, assert our **recognised customary rights** to the land at [place], which was taken without our consent and without the compensation the law requires. We call for the redress the law mandates: [compensation/rehousing].

8C. Request for Information

To: the relevant state authority

Subject: Request for information on [project] at [place]

We, [community/organisation], request the **concession, the terms, and the consultation record** for [project] at [place]. As the customary holders of this land, we are entitled to know. Please provide the documents.

8D. Engaging the Traditional Authorities

To: the [Traditional Authorities]

Subject: Defend our community's customary land at [place]

We write to our traditional leaders. The land at [place], held by our community, has been taken by [extractor] without the consent the law requires of you. We ask you to affirm our customary rights and stand with us for redress, as the Traditional Authorities' role grounds such claims.

8E. Notice to the Extractor

To: [extractor]

Subject: Redress for the displacement at [place]

We, [community/organisation], inform you that your taking of our customary land at [place] displaced our families without the compensation the law requires. We call on you to make redress — compensation and rehousing — and we are pursuing our rights, with our allies, through the courts.

8F. Approach to a Lawyer or Rights Organisation

To: [lawyer / rights organisation]

Subject: Help us win redress for displacement at [place]

We seek your help to bring a case for **compensation and rehousing** for our community, displaced by [extractor] from our customary land at [place], as such a case won homes for the displaced families of Huíla. We can provide our rights and our evidence.

8G. Email to a Journalist

To: [journalist]

Subject: Story tip: a community displaced by extraction wins redress — [specific finding]

I follow your coverage of [beat]. We have a national — and international — story, with a clear hook: a powerful extractor took our ancestral, customary land at [place] and left families homeless, and [we are pursuing / we won] redress through the courts, as the Huíla families did. I can share our evidence, with care for safety. Could we talk?

8H. Public Statement

To: the public and the authorities

Subject: [Coalition] will win redress for the displaced of [place]

We, [coalition], will not let the displacement of our families from their customary land at [place] pass without redress. As the Huíla community, standing on its customary rights and with the Church, won homes for the displaced through the courts, we will assert our rights, stand with our allies, and seek justice — lawfully, and

with care for our people's safety.

Using the Templates Well

Send important communications so that receipt is provable, log every one in your timeline, and — given the danger — weigh carefully what to put in writing and how to protect those who sign. The record of an assertion of rights, a request, or a notice is itself evidence, and matters more where the state favours the extractor. Keep them factual, specific, and grounded in the customary right, the harm, and the redress; route them, where you can, through a strong ally, whose standing lends both weight and protection. The reply, or the silence, becomes part of your record, and in Angola that record feeds the levers that matter most: the customary rights, the institutional ally, the courts, and the Traditional Authorities that won the Huíla families their homes.

IF YOU HAVE LITTLE TIME OR FEW RESOURCES: THE RAPID-FIRE VERSION

Not everyone can run a years-long campaign — and in Angola safety must come first. With a few hours a week you can still do real work to win redress for your community. In rough order of impact for the effort:

- 1. Find a strong ally.** Approach the Church's justice-and-peace commission or a rights organisation (8A).
- 2. Establish your customary rights.** Affirm them with your Traditional Authorities (8B, 8D).
- 3. Document the displacement.** Record the taken land, the lost homes, the missing compensation (Step 2).
- 4. Approach a lawyer for redress.** Seek a case for compensation and rehousing (8F).
- 5. Engage the Traditional Authorities.** Ground your claim in their consent and standing (8D).
- 6. Draw careful attention.** Reach the press and international networks, safely (8G).
- 7. Persist, protect your people, and value redress.** Homes and recognition are real; safety comes first.

Do only the first three and you will have found an ally, established your rights, and documented the harm — the foundation of an Angolan campaign. Then come back and read the rest. Even the shortest version has a spine: find a strong ally, establish your customary rights, document the harm — and keep your people safe.

WHEN THE SYSTEM IS TILTED

Angola's system, with recognised customary rights, strong institutions like the Church, courts that can order redress, and a place in an international community that watches how extraction treats the displaced, offers a community real tools — but it is tilted in specific and grave ways you must understand, so you neither waste effort nor endanger your people.

Where the Tilt Shows

The tilt here is real and serious, and this guide will not soften it. The **state owns the land and favours extraction**, and treats resistance harshly. The **courts are slow and costly**, and cases run for years. The win is usually **redress — compensation, rehousing — not a project stopped**. And, gravely, **resistance is dangerous**: community members have been **arrested and tried** for protecting their land, and protesters elsewhere have been **killed**. Where these tilts bite, a campaign that assumes the state will protect a

community against a wanted extractor, or that direct confrontation is safe, will be disappointed — or worse — which is precisely why the distinctive strategy is to ground the case in customary rights, stand with a strong ally, pursue redress through the courts, and above all keep the people safe, rather than risk a dangerous confrontation.

What Still Works — And Some Is Real

The decisive point is that even against this grave tilt, Angola's levers are real, and some are strong.

Customary rights still give a foundation. Recognised rights are a real legal handle, as they were in Huíla.

A strong ally still multiplies and protects a community. An institution like the Church lends reach, standing, and some safety.

The courts can still order redress. Slowly and imperfectly, they can require compensation and rehousing, as they did in Huíla.

The Traditional Authorities still carry legitimacy. Their consent and standing strengthen a claim.

Careful attention still lends weight and protection. The world's eyes can raise the cost of harming those who resist.

The Honest Frame

So the honest frame for Angola is realistic, sober, and safety-conscious: the state favours extraction, the courts are slow, the win is usually redress, and — gravely — resistance is dangerous; but customary rights, a strong ally, the courts, and the Traditional Authorities give a community real levers, and winning redress, recognition, and precedents is a real, if partial, victory. So diagnose your fight honestly: **assert customary rights; win a strong ally; document the harm; press the courts for redress; engage the Traditional Authorities — and keep your people safe above all.** Do not assume displacement by a powerful extractor must go unanswered; the Huíla community won homes and recognition, through law and alliance — and did so without paying the terrible price that dangerous confrontation elsewhere has exacted.

WHEN IT'S ACTUAL CORRUPTION — AND WHO IS CAPTURED

Angola has long struggled with corruption and with the capture of the state by extractive interests, and displacement for extraction without compensation is often its face, so this section matters. When a community is driven from its land not for the public good but for an extractor's profit, and left uncompensated in defiance of the law, your strategy includes exposing that — carefully.

How to Tell

Look for the signatures of a captured or extractive-friendly process. **Customary land taken without the consent of the Traditional Authorities**, as the law requires; **displacement without the compensation or rehousing the law mandates**, as the Huíla families suffered; **concessions granted opaquely** to powerful or connected extractors; **the community's rights ignored** and its resistance met with force; and **officials profiting** from the extraction. Trace the concession and the taking: how it was granted, who profits, and whether the customary rights and the law were honoured. In Angola, a community displaced without compensation for a powerful extractor's profit is worth examining for the interests behind it — with care for the danger.

Who Can Be Captured — and Who Is Harder

Be clear-eyed about where capture reaches. **Parts of the state**, tied to extraction, can favour an extractor and treat resistance as a crime. But some forces are far harder to capture, and they are your targets: the **courts**, slow but able to order redress, as Huíla showed; the **customary land rights** and the **Traditional Authorities**; the **Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission** and other strong institutions, whose independence and reach the powerful cannot easily buy; the **international rights and Church networks**; and the **community** itself. Distinctively, the standing of the Church and the recognition of customary rights are checks that extractive money finds hard to overcome. Your task is to document the displacement and the capture, and bring them — safely — to the courts, the ally, the international networks, and the public.

What to Do

Do not assume a powerful extractor's displacement cannot be answered. Instead, **document it precisely** — the customary right, the taking without consent, the missing compensation, the interest served — and take it, carefully, to the forces that can act: the **courts**; the **Church's commission** or another strong ally; the **international networks**; and the **public**. Pair the exposure with the customary right and the strong ally, so the harm and the claim arrive together. In Angola, exposing displacement for a powerful extractor's profit, and pressing the customary right and the redress owed through the courts with a strong ally, is often the way to win at least redress — as the Huíla families' recognised rights and the Church's commission moved a court to order homes for the displaced. Do this with the greatest care, for challenging the powerful in Angola has cost people their freedom and their lives. This warning is not rhetorical, and it must shape every choice a campaign makes. Because the danger is real — arrests, trials, and, elsewhere, deaths — the exposure of corruption and displacement in Angola should be pursued through the safest available channels: the courts, a strong protective institution such as the Church, and international networks whose attention raises the cost of retaliation, rather than through confrontation that puts individuals in the open. Documentation should be gathered and held carefully; individuals should be named only with their knowing consent; and the campaign should lean, wherever it can, on the standing of an ally that the powerful hesitate to strike at. To fight the powerful in Angola is possible, as Huíla showed — but it must be done in a way that protects the people who fight.

INTEGRATION & TIMELINE

The five steps win what can be won when they run together — and safely. Here is how they fit across the life of a fight, which turns on the customary rights, the institutional ally, the courts, and the Traditional Authorities.

Early (Months 0–6): The Ally, the Rights, and the Record

Pin down the project, the harm, and the deciders (Step 1); document the **customary rights and the displacement** (Step 2). Find a **strong ally** and unite the **community and its Traditional Authorities** (Step 3). Move at once on what is decisive: **approach the Church's commission or a strong ally** (8A); **assert the customary rights** (8B); engage the **Traditional Authorities** (8D); and approach a **lawyer** (8F). This phase lays the foundation, and in Angola the ally won, the rights established, and the harm documented here are what carry the fight — safely.

Middle (The Years of the Case): Courts, Redress, and Protection

Sustain the community and the ally through the slow years of a case (Step 3). Turn your evidence into arguments for each audience (Turning Evidence). Press the **courts for redress** (Step 4), engage the **Traditional Authorities**, and build **careful national and international attention** (Step 5), which lends both

weight and protection. Each front feeds the others. Do the essential things steadily — the rights before the case, the ally throughout — because the grounded case a strong ally carries is what wins redress, and keeps people safer than confrontation would.

Later (The Redress, and Vigilance): The Homes, and Care

Pursue the outcome realistically within reach — **compensation ordered, homes rebuilt, customary rights recognised, a precedent set** — and then stay vigilant, because, as Huíla shows, an isolated victory needs guarding and the broader struggle continues. Vigilance here has a particular meaning: an order won must be enforced, homes promised must actually be built, and the recognition secured must be defended against reversal, so a community should not disband its coalition or release its ally the moment a judgment is handed down, but should watch the redress through to completion and stand ready to return to court if the powerful delay or evade what they have been ordered to do. Judge success honestly, and by an Angolan measure. Sometimes it is a court ordering homes for the displaced, as in Huíla. Sometimes it is a customary right recognised and a precedent set. Each is a real, if partial, victory — and each was won by a community grounded in its rights and standing with a strong ally, through law rather than a dangerous confrontation.

The Shape of a Campaign

MONTHS 0-6	Find a strong ally Establish customary rights Document displacement Engage Traditional Authorities
THE YEARS	Litigate for redress with the ally Sustain community Careful national + international attention
REDRESS	Compensation / rehousing / recognition / precedent Stay vigilant + safe -- the struggle continues

FINAL ASSESSMENT

Angola gives communities real — if hard-won, partial, and dangerous — tools, and the honest measure of this guide is how squarely it faces both their strength and their serious limits and risks.

The strengths are real and distinctive. **Customary land rights** — recognised by law for rural communities — give a genuine legal foundation, as they did in Huíla. A **strong institutional ally**, above all the Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission, lends the reach, standing, and protection a scattered rural community cannot summon alone. The **courts**, slow and imperfect, can still order compensation, rehousing, and recognition. And the **Traditional Authorities** carry a legitimacy and a legal role the powerful cannot simply erase. These are the tools that won homes for the displaced of Huíla.

The limits and dangers are just as real, and this guide states them first and throughout. The **state owns the land and favours extraction**, and treats resistance harshly. The **courts are slow and costly**. The win is usually **redress, not a project stopped**. And, gravely, **resistance is dangerous** — community members have been arrested for defending their land, and protesters elsewhere have been killed. No guide should pretend these away; in Angola, the art is to ground the case in customary rights, stand with a strong ally, pursue redress through the courts, draw careful attention, and above all keep the people safe, because winning redress and recognition for the displaced, through law and alliance rather than dangerous confrontation, is a real, if partial, victory.

So the realistic promise is this: **assert customary rights; win a strong ally; document the harm; press the courts for redress; engage the Traditional Authorities — running all of it together, and safely**. Do that, and where the rights are clear and the ally strong, you can win redress, recognition, and precedents, as Huíla did; where the state backs the project hard or the danger is too great, you can still win a record, a precedent, and the case made — without exposing your people to a price too terrible to pay. Do it as they did — a rural community that stood on its customary rights and with the Church, and won homes for the

displaced.

A last word on the rights and the ally. Angola's lesson is that a community grounded in its customary rights and standing with a strong ally can win real redress from a powerful extractor even where the state favours extraction; but that the win is usually redress rather than a stop, that the courts are slow, and that, above all, resistance is dangerous and demands the greatest care. The powerful count on your believing that the state always wins, that a poor rural community has no rights, and that resistance is hopeless or suicidal. Their advantage is the concession and the force behind it. Yours is the customary right the law recognises, the Traditional Authorities whose consent it requires, the strong ally the powerful cannot ignore, the courts that can order redress, the world's watchful eyes, and the proven fact that a displaced community won homes and recognition through law and alliance. Play to that. Establish your rights, find your ally, document the harm, press for redress, engage your traditional leaders — and protect your people above all — and treat every right recognised, every ally won, every home rebuilt, and every precedent set as a real gain, even when the project itself goes on and the whole cannot be won at once.

The tools are here, and Huíla itself proved them — partially, and with the gravest honesty about the cost and the danger: families driven from their ancestral, customary land for black-granite quarrying, left without homes or compensation; and a community that, grounded in the customary rights Angolan law recognises and standing with the Catholic Church's justice-and-peace commission, brought its case to court and won an order that the powerful must build new homes for roughly one hundred and thirty displaced families — a rare and real victory for customary land rights, even as the quarrying continued, the courts moved slowly, the win reached redress rather than a stop, and, elsewhere, those who resisted met arrest and death. What decides the outcome, in the end, is the clarity of the customary right, the strength of the ally, the patience of the courts, the legitimacy of the traditional leaders, the watchfulness of the world — and the safety and unity of a community that will not be erased. Begin, if it is safe to begin, with the ally and the rights and the record of the harm, and build from there — carefully. Communities before you have won homes and recognition from the powerful, through law and alliance and not through a price too terrible to pay. What Huíla won can be won again. So, in time, with care, and above all in safety, can yours. The path is a clear customary right, a strong and protective ally, a well-documented harm, and patient litigation for redress — pursued together, pursued through law and alliance rather than dangerous confrontation, and pursued always with the safety of your people first.